The Races Nobody Contested

84-355 Democracy's Data | House elections, 1946–2024

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Everything here runs as given. Your job is to read what comes out and say what it means.

> **Read `house-competition-brief.Rmd` first.** This lab works through the same material with the code exposed. The brief tells you what the question is and why it is hard; this shows you where each number came from.

Where did that number come from?

> *"Only about forty House seats are really in play."*

You have seen district partisanship measured from presidential votes. This is the other way to ask: **what actually happened in the House elections themselves**, in every district, in every election, since 1946.

The dataset is Gary Jacobson's, assembled over a career and still the standard source for congressional elections, carried past his last year with the Clerk of the House's official returns. **40 elections, 435 seats each.**

And before we can use it, we have to survive it.

Steps 1-3 — What one record is, how many, and the three definitions

```
d  <- read.csv("data/races.csv",  stringsAsFactors = FALSE)
by <- read.csv("data/by_year.csv", stringsAsFactors = FALSE)

c(races = nrow(d), elections = nrow(by),
  first = min(by$year), last = max(by$year),
  seats_per_election = round(mean(by$races)))
```

```
#>              races          elections              first               last
#>              17403                 40               1946               2024
#> seats_per_election
#>                435
```

Jacobson's file as distributed has **30,005 rows. 14,777 of them are empty** — no year, no votes, no candidate, nothing. Padding.

Drop them and you have **15,228 real races**: 435 seats × 35 elections, 1946 through 2014. Compute anything before that drop and every number you produce is wrong by a factor of two, silently.

This is the ordinary condition of an old research dataset. It was built for its author, who knew what was in it. Nothing warns you.

Jacobson stops at 2014. The 17,403 rows you just loaded run to 2024 because the last 2,175 races were parsed from the Clerk of the House's official returns and spliced on. That splice, not the end of the file, is where this data's real limit sits — hold onto it; we come back to it in *What this lab cannot tell you.*

Steps 4-5 — The first number, and who holds the uncontested seats

```
c(races = nrow(d),
  no_vote_share_recorded = sum(d$uncontested),
  pct = round(100 * mean(d$uncontested), 1))
```

```
#>                    races no_vote_share_recorded                    pct
#>                  17403.0                 2568.0                   14.8
```

2,568 races have no Democratic vote share. There is no "uncontested" flag in this file. There is simply a hole where the number should be.

The hole *is* the finding. `dv` is the Democratic share of the **two-party** vote, and if only one party fielded a candidate there is no two-party share to record.

Two pieces of evidence that this is what missingness means:

```
table(uncontested = d$uncontested, incumbent_won = d$incwin, useNA = "ifany")
```

```
#>            incumbent_won
#> uncontested     0     1  <NA>
#>       FALSE   771 10578  3486
#>       TRUE      2  2221   345
```

```
round(100 * tapply(d$uncontested, d$south, mean), 1)
```

```
#>    0    1
#>  7.3 34.7
```

Where the file records incumbency at all, the incumbent won 2,221 of those 2,223 races — 99.9%. And missingness runs at **34.7% in the South against 7.3% elsewhere.**

That is what an unopposed incumbent looks like in a spreadsheet.

Read the `NA` column of that table, not just the two you were looking for. 345 of the uncontested races carry no incumbency flag at all — they are the post-2014 rows, where the source changes and the flag stops existing. **Divide 2,221 by 2,568 instead of by 2,223 and you have quietly counted every one of them as "no incumbent".** The honest denominator is the races where the answer was recorded.

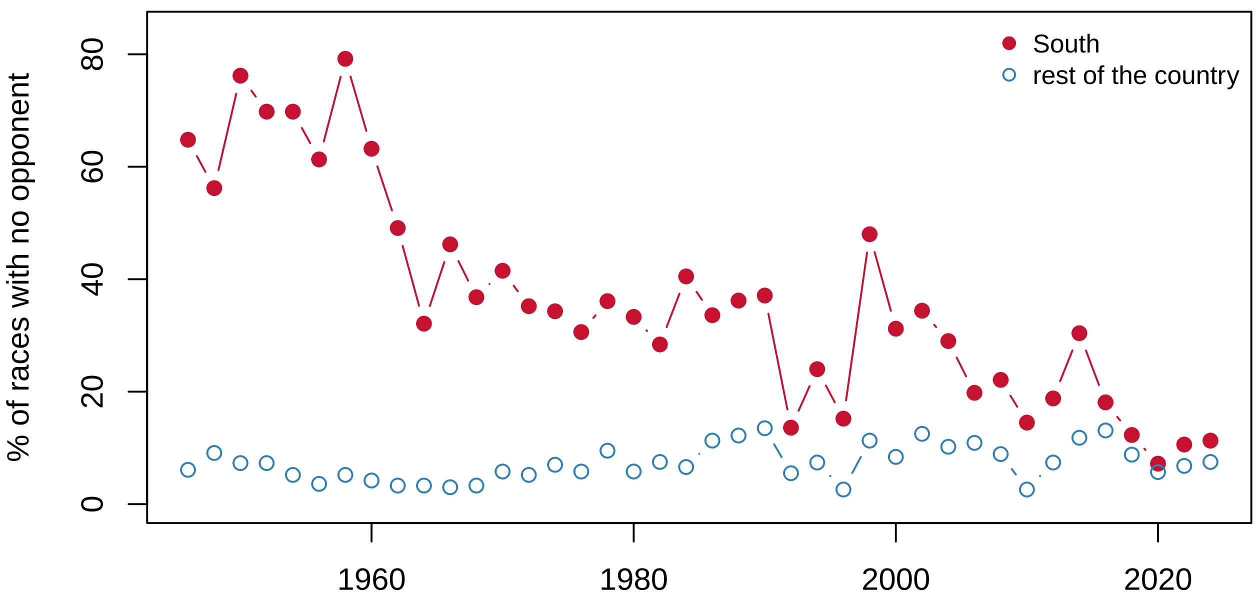
Step 6 — Split the country in two

> **Before running this, take the flat national trend seriously.** Uncontested races ran at 20.2% in 1946 and 8.7% in 2024 — and the widest single-election jump in between is 15.6 points, larger than the whole 78-year drift. That looks like noise around a line that went nowhere. **Predict what you will see if you compute the same share separately for the South and for everywhere else.**

```
by[by$year %in% c(1946, 1958, 1972, 1990, 2010, 2024),
   c("year", "pct_uncontested_south", "pct_uncontested_non_south")]
```

```
#>    year pct_uncontested_south pct_uncontested_non_south
#> 1  1946                  64.8                       6.1
#> 7  1958                  79.2                       5.2
#> 14 1972                  35.2                       5.2
#> 23 1990                  37.1                      13.5
#> 33 2010                  14.5                       2.6
#> 40 2024                  11.3                       7.5
```

```
plot(by$year, by$pct_uncontested_south, type = "b", pch = 19, col = "#C41230",
     ylim = c(0, max(by$pct_uncontested_south, by$pct_uncontested_non_south) + 5),
     xlab = "", ylab = "% of races with no opponent")
lines(by$year, by$pct_uncontested_non_south, type = "b", pch = 1, col = "#2c7fb8")
legend("topright", c("South", "rest of the country"),
       col = c("#C41230", "#2c7fb8"), pch = c(19, 1), bty = "n", cex = 0.85)
```



In the 1950s, 71.3% of Southern House races had only one candidate — 79.2% in 1958, the worst year. Not close races — *no* races. The Democratic primary was the election, and November was a formality.

By the 2010s it is **18.8%**, and **9.7%** so far in the 2020s. Meanwhile the rest of the country sat between 3.4% and 10.2% in every decade and never moved much.

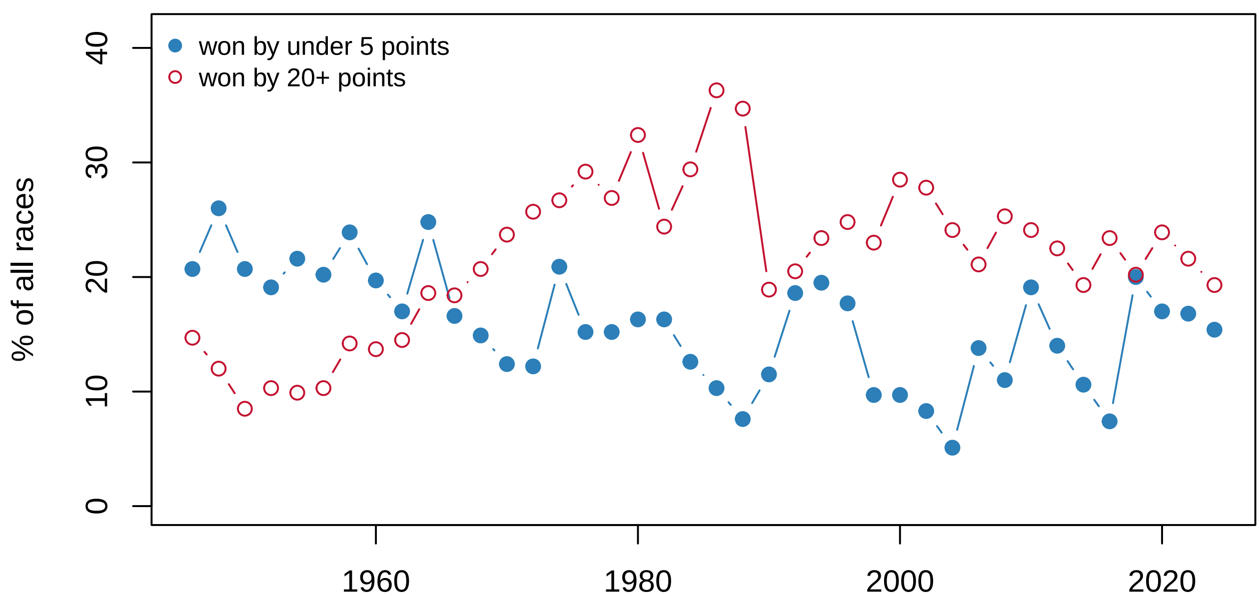
The most dramatic democratisation in modern American electoral history is visible here as a column filling in.

Steps 7-8 — Contested is not competitive, and a fourth measure

```
by[by$year %in% c(1946, 1964, 1988, 2004, 2014, 2024),
   c("year", "pct_competitive", "pct_landslide")]
```

```
#>    year pct_competitive pct_landslide
#> 1  1946            20.7          14.7
#> 10 1964            24.8          18.6
#> 22 1988             7.6          34.7
#> 30 2004             5.1          24.1
#> 35 2014            10.6          19.3
#> 40 2024            15.4          19.3
```

```
plot(by$year, by$pct_competitive, type = "b", pch = 19, col = "#2c7fb8",
     ylim = c(0, max(by$pct_competitive, by$pct_landslide) + 5),
     xlab = "", ylab = "% of all races")
lines(by$year, by$pct_landslide, type = "b", pch = 1, col = "#C41230")
legend("topleft", c("won by under 5 points", "won by 20+ points"),
       col = c("#2c7fb8", "#C41230"), pch = c(19, 1), bty = "n", cex = 0.85)
```



Close races fell from 23.4% of all seats in the 1940s to 9.6% in the 2000s, recovering to 14.2% in the 2010s and 16.4% in the 2020s — still well below where they started. **Landslides went the other way** — 13.3% in the 1940s to a peak of 31.4% in the 1980s, and 21.6% now.

So the South stopped being uncontested, and the country as a whole got *less* competitive. Those are not contradictory: one-party dominance stopped taking the form of empty ballots and started taking the form of lopsided ones.

Step 9 — All four at once

Everything in Steps 7-8 divides by **all** races, uncontested ones included. That is a choice, and it changes the answer.

```r
cont <- d[!d$uncontested, ]
dec <- function(x, y) round(100 * tapply(x, 10 * (y %/% 10), mean), 1)

rbind(all_races        = dec(d$competitive, d$year),
      contested_only   = dec(cont$competitive, cont$year))
```

```
#>                1940 1950 1960 1970 1980 1990 2000 2010 2020
#> all_races      23.3 21.1 18.6 15.2 12.6 15.4  9.6 14.2 16.4
#> contested_only 29.3 26.9 21.6 17.6 15.0 17.8 11.3 16.1 17.8
```

Among all races, competitive seats fell from 23.3% in the 1940s to 9.6% in the 2000s. Among contested races only, from 29.3% to 11.3%.

Both are true. They answer different questions — *what share of seats were in play* versus *when somebody bothered to run, how close was it* — and an uncontested race is arguably the least competitive race there is, which argues for keeping it in.

Nobody who quotes one of these numbers tells you which one it is. You have now met this exact problem in the midterm-penalty lab, in the turnout labs, and in election administration. It is the same question every time: *per what?*

Step 10 — What you can now say

You can say that American House elections did not become less competitive in a straight line, and did not become more competitive either. **One region's one-party system was dismantled while the rest of the country drifted toward having one of its own**, and the two motions roughly cancel in the national number.

You can say non-competition is an elite decision, not a voter verdict: of the uncontested races whose incumbency the file records, 99.9% had one — which means a party looked at a seat with a sitting member in it and declined to run anybody.

You cannot say why. This file has no candidate quality, no fundraising and no district boundaries, so redistricting, geographic sorting and party recruitment cannot be separated here.

Your turn

Change **one** thing, re-run, and write about what changed. Pick one.

Option A — Midterms. `races.csv` has a `midterm` flag. Are midterm elections more or less competitive than presidential-year ones? Before running it, write down what you expect and why — then check. (`incwin` is empty after 2014, so keep this one to `competitive` and `uncontested`, which are recorded for all 17,403 races.)

Option B — Split districts. `split_district` is TRUE where the district's presidential and House winners came from different parties. Plot its share over time (`pct_split` in `by_year.csv`). What does the trend say about how nationalised congressional elections have become, and when did it change?

> **Note the source change at 2014.** Everything from 2016 on is parsed from the Clerk of the House's official statistics rather than Jacobson's file. The `source` column in `races.csv` says

which is which, and `dvp` is empty for every one of those rows — so the denominator shifts at the splice as well as with coverage.

Two traps in this one, both deliberate. First, `pct_split` is `NA` for 5 elections — check `split_coverage` before you plot, and say in your write-up what you did with the gaps. Second, the file has both a `dvp` and a `dpres` column. **`dvp` is "Democratic vote, *previous* election", not "presidential"**; an earlier version of this lab used it by mistake and reported seat turnover as split districts for a term. Use `dpres`.

Option C — The South, defined. The `south` flag is one researcher's list of states. Look at which states it includes (`unique(d$state[d$south == 1])`), and say whether the Step 6 finding depends on that choice. What would you do with border states?

Option D — Your own question. 17,403 races, 40 elections, 78 years.

What this lab cannot tell you

- **Who ran.** No candidate names, no parties of challengers, no quality measures. "Uncontested" here is inferred from a missing number, not read from a list of candidates.
- **Why nobody ran.** A seat can go uncontested because it is hopeless, because the party is disorganised, or because a deal was struck. This data cannot distinguish them.
- **Who was sitting in the seat, after 2014.** The file does not end there — it runs to 2024 — but it *changes source* there. Jacobson supplies 15,228 races through 2014; the Clerk of the House supplies the remaining 2,175 from 2016 on, and the Clerk's tables report votes, not careers. **`incwin` and `dvp` are empty for all 2,175 of those rows.** Vote shares, margins, uncontested races and competitiveness cross the splice intact; incumbency and the previous election's result do not. A claim about incumbency computed over the whole file will silently answer a question about 1946–2014 and label it 1946–2024. That is the boundary in this data, and it is invisible unless you look at `source`.
- **Whether `dv` missing *always* means uncontested.** It is an inference from the incumbent-won pattern and the regional concentration, not a documented flag. A handful of the 2,568 may be missing for other reasons.

On the discussion board

By **Friday, 11:59 p.m.** A sentence or two is enough.

Three that would make good posts:

- In the 1950s, 71.3% of Southern House races had one candidate. What does that do to your idea of what "an election" is?
- Competition fell even as uncontested races became rarer. How can both be true?
- The uncontested races are a hole in a column, not a label. What else might you have missed in a dataset because absence was the signal?

Where the data came from

Gary C. Jacobson's House elections dataset, 1946–2014 — the standard source for congressional elections research, held locally in this repository, and 15,228 of the 17,403 races here.

The Clerk of the House's official election statistics, 2016–2024 — parsed from the published PDFs in `data/`, and the remaining 2,175 races. The two sources overlap for several elections and agree closely on vote shares, which is why the splice is usable; they do not carry the same columns, which is why `incwin` and `dvp` stop at 2014.

14,777 of Jacobson's 30,005 rows are empty padding and must be dropped, and **uncontested races appear as a missing vote share rather than a flag.** Both are handled and documented in `data/build-data.R`. `split_district` comes from the file's own `split` column, which was checked against a recomputation from `dv` and `dpres` before being trusted — an earlier build had it backwards, and `data/build-data.R` records how that was settled. Where `dpres` does not exist the series is masked rather than reported, which is why `pct_split` is `NA` for 5 elections.